eCall
In European countries a system called eCall is in process of implementation by 2010. In case of an accident, the system will automatically place a call to the nearby emergency center

Artificial passenger
Artificial Passenger is a device invented by IBM to ensure that the drivers don't fall asleep (or get lonely!). It is capable of making conversions, asking questions, controlling the car stereo, even telling the driver to take a break and sleep


Assisted parking offered by the Lexus LS 600 is the ultimate in point, click, and forget: just select where you need to park using the dashboard and let the car do the rest!

still laugh at a Twin V8 Turbo engine powering a Maruti 800.

Over time you'll notice a trend that cars tend to get curvier, and generally more pleasing to the eye, ever new models come with at least one corner replaced by a curve. Companies spend large amounts of money to ensure the entire body of the car seems like one smooth unbroken surface, a technique called Class A surfacing. Not only does this make the cars more visually pleasing, but also more streamlined. So you see the curves have a purpose, as always. We are getting faster and faster cars, and the externals of the car are starting to matter more.

The concept of concept
If you open up any car magazine you are sure to find those car renderings which seem like squashed-down stealth aircraft, until you squint and see signs of wheels and a label somewhere saying 'Concept Model'. Are these cars destined only to live in our dreams? If you look at concept car drawings from decades ago, they will look like the same wacky, contrived designs we see in concept cars today. The only difference is that today they are much closer to reality. Which is not saying much, since many of those designs are likely never to come out. Such assaults to our senses are best humoured only in car exhibitions and magazines. Hey, but a guy can drool, can't he?

Most of these cars are meant to show off a new philosophy of car design and will usually undergo a lot of changes before they are eventually released for purchase. This also helps the manufacturers garner early feedback from people before they commit to a new design which will cost millions. This doesn't mean that concepts never come to fruition, on rare occasions manufacturers have released concepts, such as the *2002 Pontiac Solstice* which was released in 2006.

Do androids dream of electric cars?
We have come a long way from the clunky, boxy monstrosities that our ancestors called cars. Cars are no longer a privilege of the privileged, more a convenient conveyance for the common man. We can dream of teleportation, but in all probability we will be driving our cars (or be driven by them!) for many, many years to come. Until better means become available, cars will get faster, better looking, lighter, cheaper and less polluting.

Today, we find ourselves in an uncomfortable time where our knowledge and thus our judgment would have us abandon the polluting monsters that ply the roads. Those who have the means and care enough, have already begun to switch to greener technologies, but they will need to get much cheaper if any kind of mass adoption is to be expected.

A few years ago, before computers, the internet, and GPS, a lot of today's car technologies would have been inconceivable. Who would have thought about intelligent cars back then? Or in fact any kind of inanimate intelligence. Intelligence is a property that we associate increasingly with devices as well as with humans these days.

It is quite likely that some of the technologies that we will see in the cars of tomorrow are based on technologies that we cannot yet imagine. What remains to be seen is whether our cars can get smarter, faster than we get dumber. d

DREAM ELECTRIC

The Tesla Roadster
Here is another reason to go electric besides the usual excuse of saving-the-environment: The Tesla Roadster.

This petite, yet powerful, beast will take you from 0 to 100 KPH in under 4 seconds, while still maintaining its composure. You can burn the road at its top speed of 200 KPH, and still expect a mileage of 50 KPL, enough to put your neighbour's motorcycle to shame! Designed as a sports car, it gives some of the best performance characteristics for electric cars. On a single charge, it can whisk you away as far as 375 Km thanks to its battery pack of 6,831 lithium ion cells, which Tesla refers to as its Energy Storage System. Even after all this it needs only 3 ½ hours to charge! It has a smooth carbon fibre body, and a powerful 3-phase 4-pole electric motor capable of an impressive 285 hp (315 hp for the Sports version), and an efficiency of as much as 90 per cent.

This is the first car developed by *Tesla Motors*, which is a rather new company that focuses on electric cars. The *Tesla Roadster* was a joint effort with *Lotus Cars*, which supplied some components and technology, and the car itself was assembled in a *Lotus* factory. The internals of the car (motor, electronics etc) were developed by *Tesla Motors* itself, based on technology licensed from *AC Propulsion*.

Despite it's pure awesomeness, it comes at a somewhat reasonable (for a one of a kind electric powered sports car) price of $98,000.

Go book it today for your 40th birthday!